

Can the behaviourist provide a convincing account of how we can know other people's mental states? What about our own?

Rylean, or philosophical, behaviourism, is a theory that rejects the Cartesian picture of the mind as an inner, private object separate from the body. It instead defines the mind and mental states in terms of patterns of behaviour, and dispositions to behave in various circumstances. It comes as a direct rebuttal to Cartesian dualism, as he calls Descartes' definition of the mind- and the separation of the mind and body into two different 'substances' (Descartes, 1641/1984)- a 'category mistake' (Ryle, 1949). Ryle argues that treating the mind as an inner, 'ghost-like' object is a fundamental error in classification, and that mental concepts, such as beliefs, desires and intentions, should lie in a different logical category. According to Ryle, these terms do not refer to occult, inner states of the mind hidden from third parties; he says that to 'believe' that Paris is in France, is simply to be disposed to answer questions, navigate maps, and act in ways showing that belief. The appeal of this view is that it solves the problem of knowing 'other minds' by making the mind a public entity by definition. If the mind is identical to observable behaviour, nothing is private or inner- we can know another mind's state just by watching it.

In a crude form, this seems to imply that if a person got stabbed, they would only become 'in pain' the moment they started screaming, said the words 'I am in pain' or otherwise manifested the relevant dispositions- until that moment there would be no pain, only bodily damage. This sounds highly implausible- naturally we know they will experience the qualitative feeling of being in pain from the moment of injury, whether they manifest it or not. Such cases suggest that mental states should not be identified purely with overt behaviour, and that behaviourism risks leaving out the experiential aspect of mental states altogether.

Even leaving qualia aside, behaviourism seems unable to provide a complete account of how we can know other people's mental states for some very simple reasons, such as the fact that people tend to think one way and act another surprisingly often. Behavioural economics theory outlines the difference between 'stated preferences', which are what we say we prefer; and 'revealed preferences', which are inferred from our choices (Samuelson, 1938). We are prone to showing behaviour that directly conflicts with our true mental states, whether we are intentionally acting or being deceptive, or simply do not have good enough self-awareness. We can, for example, subconsciously conform to social pressures in a social situation and unintentionally agree with a controversial statement we wouldn't actually agree with privately upon reflection. A strict behaviourist would observe our accidental agreement, take it for face value, and ascribe us to the belief expressed in the remark- therefore inaccurately understanding our true beliefs.

Behaviours can also be misinterpreted- the behaviourist holds the responsibility to interpret their observations correctly. The Geach-Chisholm (1957) objection states that it is inappropriate to map a behaviour such as running away from a snake, to exclusively one corresponding mental state such a phobia of snakes, since reality is much more complex.

Whether an ophidiophobic person runs away from a snake depends not only on their disposition of fear, but also a network of further beliefs and desires simultaneously, such as a belief that the snake is dangerous, a belief that running away is a viable escape method, or even a desire to survive. Conversely, even someone who does recognise the danger of the snake and realises they can safely escape, might not in fact run away if they lack a desire to preserve their life. A behaviourist may observe an ophidiophobe approaching this snake, without the knowledge that they are suicidal, and wrongly conclude that they are not afraid of snakes.

Radical behaviourism, developed by B.F. Skinner (1977), takes a more scientific, psychological approach to the link between the mind and behaviour than Ryle's philosophical behaviourism. Despite fundamental differences, their commonalities make them a relevant comparison. Both views downplay or reject appealing to inner, unobservable mental states as explanatory causes for behaviour, instead focusing only on what can be observed. While Ryle provides conceptual analysis of mental states in terms of actions and dispositions, Skinner, and other experimental behaviourists such as Ivan Pavlov (1927), scientifically investigated how behaviour is shaped by environmental factors. Their studies on operant and classical conditioning suggest that behavioural patterns are learnt and can be explained by environmental reinforcement, without giving credit to inner mental objects. These theories fit well with Ryle's emphasis on observable behaviour and provide empirical grounding for the behavioural patterns Ryle talks about.

However, both philosophical and psychological behaviourism face a similar epistemic limitation. All we can do is observe the behaviour, even if predictably, and then provide some theory for why it happens. They may offer useful, or even valid, explanations of behaviour, but they do not give us any insight into what the subject is really thinking or experiencing. It is not impossible that Pavlov's dog had an intentional thought process of *"watch what I can make Pavlov do. As soon as I drool, he'll smile and write in his little book"* (Stivers, 2003), rather than merely undergoing the automatic process of operant conditioning. Although it is extremely unlikely for a dog to actually think this way, the joke makes a serious point that we are also similarly susceptible to conditioning and this sort of intentional deception is very possible with humans. Both kinds of behaviourism provide, at best, a seemingly logical story that links observed bodily manifestations to hypothetical inner processes. They do not reveal the private intentions of the mind committing the act; we still do not know what is happening 'behind the curtain'.

The behaviourist may counter that the 'mind' is actually what is in front of the curtain, rather than behind. However, this claim seems to disagree with our general, established understanding of the term. Standard dictionary definitions of the word 'mind' typically refer to the 'ghost-like' phenomena such as thought, feelings, consciousness and experience, all of which we naturally locate behind the curtain of our skin, and in the brain. This suggests that not only does behaviourism attempt to describe the mind, but is proposing a fundamental revision of our common conception of it in which mental states are identified with and defined by our outward behaviour or disposition. If our widely accepted understanding of the mind refers to inner aspects of our lives, then a theory that focuses exclusively on the outer, observable, behavioural

parts is unlikely to provide a complete account of another person's true mental state, especially if it relies on behaviourism alone.

Behaviourism rightly emphasises that there is a close connection between mental states and behaviour. For the average person, it is extremely difficult to be in severe pain without manifesting it in any observable way. It is therefore natural to treat someone's behaviour as an at least partially reliable indicator of what they may be thinking or feeling.

The 'Super-Spartan' thought experiment presents a subject who trains himself to never display any reaction to pain. Taking this even further, we can consider a subject who aims to become a 'perfect stoic'. He trains to eliminate not only reactions to pain, but any outward sign that might reveal his mental state, practically exhibiting no observable behaviour at all.

However, even this impossibly extreme example, can be re-described by the behaviourist simply as a pattern of 'stoic behaviour', manifesting his inner mental state of desire to become stoic. The very attempt to conceal his mental state becomes evidence of those states, because it is impossible to 'not behave'. The fact that even a lack of behaviour does not refute behaviourism- which relies on behaviour- makes behaviourism seem potentially unfalsifiable and thin due to its elasticity. This example makes it unclear whether the mental state has been actually explained, or just re-labelled.

Ultimately, behaviourism at least provides a starting point for knowing others' mental states. We all are behaving in some way whether we want to or not, and our behaviours reflect some reason or cause whether we are conscious of them or not. Of course, it is easier to infer the reason or cause with our most basic and instinctual mental states- if someone is screaming and bleeding, they are probably in pain, and if they are eating, they probably feel hungry. However, minds have the propensity to obscure their more complex behaviours, intentionally or not, producing behaviour that diverges from their true beliefs, desires or feelings. Without doing additional detective work, it is difficult to identify this obscurity, therefore we shouldn't judge people's mental states solely using the behaviourist method. In practice, our judgements about others' mental states also rely on other things such as contextual information, knowledge of the person, their own testimony, as well as our own capacity to imagine what it would be like to be that person.

To assess the ability of the behaviourist to provide an account of our own minds, we must address the asymmetry between self-knowledge, and knowledge of others. I may know others' mental states primarily through observation, whereas I appear to know and experience my own mind directly from the inside. For Ryle, however, self-knowledge is not a matter of peering into a private realm, but of knowing how I am disposed to behave in various circumstances- to know that I am in pain, is essentially to know how I am disposed to react and respond when I am hurt.

This picture seems to get self-knowledge the wrong way around. If 'pain' was identical to a pattern of 'pain behaviour', then I would need to first observe my own behaviour to know that I am in pain. Yet, I can know that I am in pain before the moment I wince or state the words 'I am in pain' (which would let others know that I am in pain at that moment), even if I successfully suppress any such outward signs. I have 'privileged access' to my own mind, and I have the ability of introspection unmediated by observation of my behaviour.

However, our introspective abilities and privileged access are not infallible. We do not have perfect 'in corrigible' access to our own minds as Descartes envisaged. Contemporary philosophy and psychology suggest that our minds are vulnerable to subconscious processes, biases and introspective 'illusions' which may distort how we understand ourselves. Nevertheless, the knowledge we have of ourselves is far wider than even of our closest friends or family members, simply because we have continuous access to our mental lives in a way that others do not.

Importantly, we have exclusive access to our own qualitative experiences. Even a parent who has known me my whole life, and knows everything there is to know about me, cannot literally experience what 'it is like' to be me. This asymmetry in access to qualia reinforces the idea that the behavioural resources offered by behaviourism alone, are not enough for a plausible account of self-knowledge.

As mentioned earlier, the ability to imagine or simulate what it would be like to be another person is crucial in forming an idea of their mental state. This capacity can otherwise be described as empathy, and it stands to our knowledge of other minds, much like how self-awareness stands to our knowledge of our own. Both are fallible yet learnable skills which, when combined with observation of behaviour, form a much richer account of mental states than behaviourism alone. Thought experiments such as Thomas Nagel's *'What is it like to be a bat?'* (1974) and Frank Jackson's *'Mary's Room'* (1986) highlight both the power and the limitations of this imaginative route.

In both cases, we are asked to imagine being in a mental state different from our current one, while possessing complete theoretical knowledge about that mind. In Nagel's case, we imagine the mind of a completely different being to us- a bat. We know everything there is to know about bats' behaviour- flying around, not being able to see, making clicking sounds and noticing how long it takes for the echo of that click to return to you, sleeping upside down, et cetera. In Jackson's case, for argument's sake we can imagine that Mary is us and that we know all the physical and behavioural facts about colour vision, but have never seen the colour red and must imagine what it would be like to see it for the first time. In both cases, there seems to be a certain kind of knowledge missing just beyond our grasp, even if we are Mary and are essentially just introspecting into a variation of our own minds where we have never seen the colour red. When Mary sees red for the first time, it would be natural to say that she does learn something new, despite her previous, apparently exhaustive, knowledge. There is a contrast between the third-person knowledge, and the first-person experiential qualia which are crucially missing from the pure behaviourist view.

Ultimately, we can never perfectly know or imagine the state of another mind, especially judging solely off the behaviour of the body attached to that mind. Actions and dispositions are a great starting source of evidence, since there is always a reason for everything we do, even when we are not fully aware of it. However given our human proneness to deceive and act, intentionally or not, outward behaviour should not always be fully relied on. Sometimes we need other sources of evidence of the mind state, such as contextual knowledge, empathising, or simply asking the person to share their inner introspective insights with you. The more we learn about a person's behavioural patterns of action and reaction, the better equipped we are to understand their mental state. Although, this understanding relies on methods outside of the behaviourist's reach. To ignore empathy, and to judge a bat or fellow human solely by what they do and how they act, is shallow and limits greatly our ability to know others' minds.

We may never know, or more specifically feel, 'what it is like to be a bat', but we can surely get a pretty good idea with enough knowledge and imagination. It may be easier to approximate other human's experiences more closely than a bat's since we share a more similar form of life and can relate to each other better.

As for our own minds, we are already currently knowing our own minds to a certain extent- we are continuously experiencing our feelings, whether we choose to act on them, or observe them, or not. Our introspection is not infallible- we may have personal biases that sometimes make us view others through a more accurate lens than ourselves, but ultimately, we know and feel things about ourselves no behaviourist could ever learn through observation.

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